Town of Hilton Head Island
TOWN COUNCIL WORKSHOP MEETING
Tuesday, July 28, 2026, 3:00 PM
Minutes

Call to Order

Mayor Perry called the meeting to order at 3:00 p.m.

Council Members present: Alan Perry, Mayor; Alex Brown, Ward 1, Mayor Pro-Tempore; Patsy Brison, Ward 2; Steve DeSimone, Ward 3; Tammy Becker, Ward 4; Steve Alfred, Ward 5; Melinda Tunner, Ward 6

Others Present: Marc Orlando, Town Manager; Brittany Ward, Town Attorney; Kim Gammon, Town Clerk

Adoption of the Agenda

Mayor Perry requested a motion be made to amend the Agenda by moving Public Comment - Non Agenda Items before the Workshop Discussion. Mr. Brown moved to approve. Ms. Brison seconded. Motion carried 7-0.

Ms. Brison moved to approve the amended Agenda. Ms. Becker seconded. Motion carried 7-0.

Workshop Discussion

Review and Discussion of Proposed William Hilton Parkway Gateway Corridor Master Plan

Mayor Perry began the meeting by stating that the Workshop Meeting is taking place to address traffic issues within the corridor and to ensure everyone will have a clear understanding of how to move forward, so a plan can be delivered to Council in August for a Resolution in support of Town staff in order to begin working on obtaining funding and moving the process forward.

Mr. Orlando recalled that the last time Council was together was April 28, 2026, as they worked on the Gateway Corridor Master Plan (Master Plan), and this Workshop is taking place as a continuation of project planning and to hear continued feedback on the work itself.

Mr. Orlando reminded Town Council that he was directed to advance a coordinated Master Planning effort for the William Hilton Gateway Corridor Project. As a result of the coordinated Town Council and Beaufort County efforts on the use of the 2018 Beaufort County Transportation Referendum proceeds, all of which were allocated to the eastbound bridge, Town Council is left with a project plan in place and a Master Plan expectation to advance.

Council, the Mayor and Town Manager have since updated traffic projections, refined accident data, confirmed that no additional private property is impacted by the Master Plan and reviewed and separated project components and sequencing in connection with establishing priority and pricing. Additionally, Town Council adopted the FY 2027 Consolidated Budget which included an allocation for the Squire Pope Road/Spanish Wells Road capital program dollars for those intersections as well as the roads themselves.

Brian Kinzelman of the firm, MKSK, explained that the bridge will be done in separate phases. The first phase is the eastbound three-lane bridge, striped for two lanes, then, over time, a second new bridge will be built westbound and as those new bridges come online, their respective aged counterparts will be demolished. He also summarized what actions have taken place since the April 28, 2026, Town Council Workshop Meeting.

Safety and Operations Clarity

- Updated traffic projections using latest 2025 SCDOT data.
- Added Squire Pope movement diagrams and intersection analysis.
- Finalized traffic simulation modeling.
- Reinforced proposed 40 mph speed limit.
- Prioritized dangerous intersections within implementation sequencing.

Outreach + Property Impact Study

- Reinforced direct access to/from William Hilton Parkway for Stewart properties and proposed pedestrian bridge crossing.
- Confirmed no right-of-way impacts to privately held properties, including the Humane Association and the Stewart family.
- Acknowledged additional corridor needs outside the study scope (Gum Tree, CIP Merge, Wilborn, etc.).

Implementation Clarity

- Reviewed and further separated project components to clarify costs.
- Provided funding strategy overview.
- Improved overall project documentation and presentation materials.

Mr. Kinzelman also gave an overview of the Master Plan Objective and the Corridor Guiding Principles as provided by a community committee:

Master Plan Objective: Develop a comprehensive William Hilton Parkway Gateway Corridor Master Plan that will define the future of U.S. 278 from the Moss Creek western limits of the Island through the historic Stoney Community and across the Island's main gateway.
Consultant Team Role: Use local knowledge to create community-based solutions that

enhance safety, community preservation and character.

Corridor Guiding Principles:

- Fix transportation issues in the corridor to enhance safety and quality of life for all residents, workers and visitors.
- Improve safety and quality of life for the residents/neighborhoods/businesses directly impacted by the corridor improvements.
- Create a gateway to Hilton Head Island that the region will be proud of.
- Improve hurricane/emergency evacuation route.

Mr. Kinzelman also provided the South Carolina Department of Transportation's (SCDOT) expectations regarding a successful corridor as well as the SCDOT's key metrics:

SCDOT Core Goals for a Successful Corridor:

- Efficient Connections - provide reliable, high-quality links between major economic hubs, enabling seamless travel and trade.
- Economic Vitality - enhance South Carolina's competitiveness by creating an interconnected, intermodal network for freight and goods.
- Safety and Security - maintain a safe, secure and efficient transportation system.
- Resource Protection - protect and enhance natural, historical and cultural resources along the corridor.

SCDOT Key Metrics:

- Intersection, Approach, Movement Delay and Level of Service.
- Collision Severity.
- Crash Causational Factors.
- Conflict Point Reduction.
- Geometric Continuity.
- Multimodal Accommodations (vehicles, pedestrians and bicyclists).

Dillon Turner of Kimley-Horn gave an overview of the traffic metrics through the corridor, including travel and turning motion metrics improvements to enhance the level of service through the Squire Pope/Chamberlin Drive intersection and the Spanish Wells/Wild Horse Road intersection, and explained the process by which SCDOT collects its data samples relating to traffic.

Council and the Master Plan consultant team viewed traffic performance data and proposed roadway improvements for key intersections along William Hilton Parkway (US 278), focusing on Squire Pope Road, Chamberlin Drive, Spanish Wells Road, and Wild Horse Road.

Key Points Discussed:

- 2025 vs. 2030 Levels of Service: staff clarified that color changes (green/yellow/red) represent shifts in traffic performance after proposed improvements. Some quadrants show limited improvement, while others, especially movements involving Squire Pope and Chamberlin, show clearer benefits.
- Continuous Green T Design: this configuration removes one signal phase, improving flow for on-island movements and reducing conflict points. A pedestrian bridge would be required because pedestrians cannot safely cross where on-island traffic is no longer signalized.
- Lane Configuration Questions: council members noted inconsistencies regarding added lanes shown in the slides - some depicted a third lane that isn't part of the 2030 model. Mr. Turner clarified that certain long-term lane additions fall outside the 2030 analysis horizon.
- Traffic Volume Data Differences: Council questioned discrepancies between DOT's average daily counts and a Planning Commission three-day July count showing a 68/32 directional split. Mr. Turner explained these reflect different time periods and collection methods; both sets can be accurate for their respective measurement windows.
- Crash Data at Spanish Wells & Wild Horse: this intersection has the highest crash density on the corridor. Rear-end collisions are common due to congestion and merging patterns from Cross Island Parkway. Short-term improvements primarily increase capacity (e.g., dual left turn lanes), while long-term designs aim to reduce conflict points, significantly improving safety.
- Short-Term vs. Long-Term Improvements: Council emphasized the need for clarity on what improvements are included in short-term plans versus future grade-separation concepts, especially regarding lane additions and environmental impacts (e.g., wetland concerns). Mr. Turner stated that, based on current information, short-term work is not expected to impact wetlands.
- Requests for More Detail: Multiple council members asked for quantitative measures of how much throughput improves (not just color-coded Lane of Service); capacity changes from added lanes; expected safety gains; and comparisons between short-term fixes and long-term grade-separated solutions.

Mr. Kinzelman then provided a proposed **Summary of Improvements**:

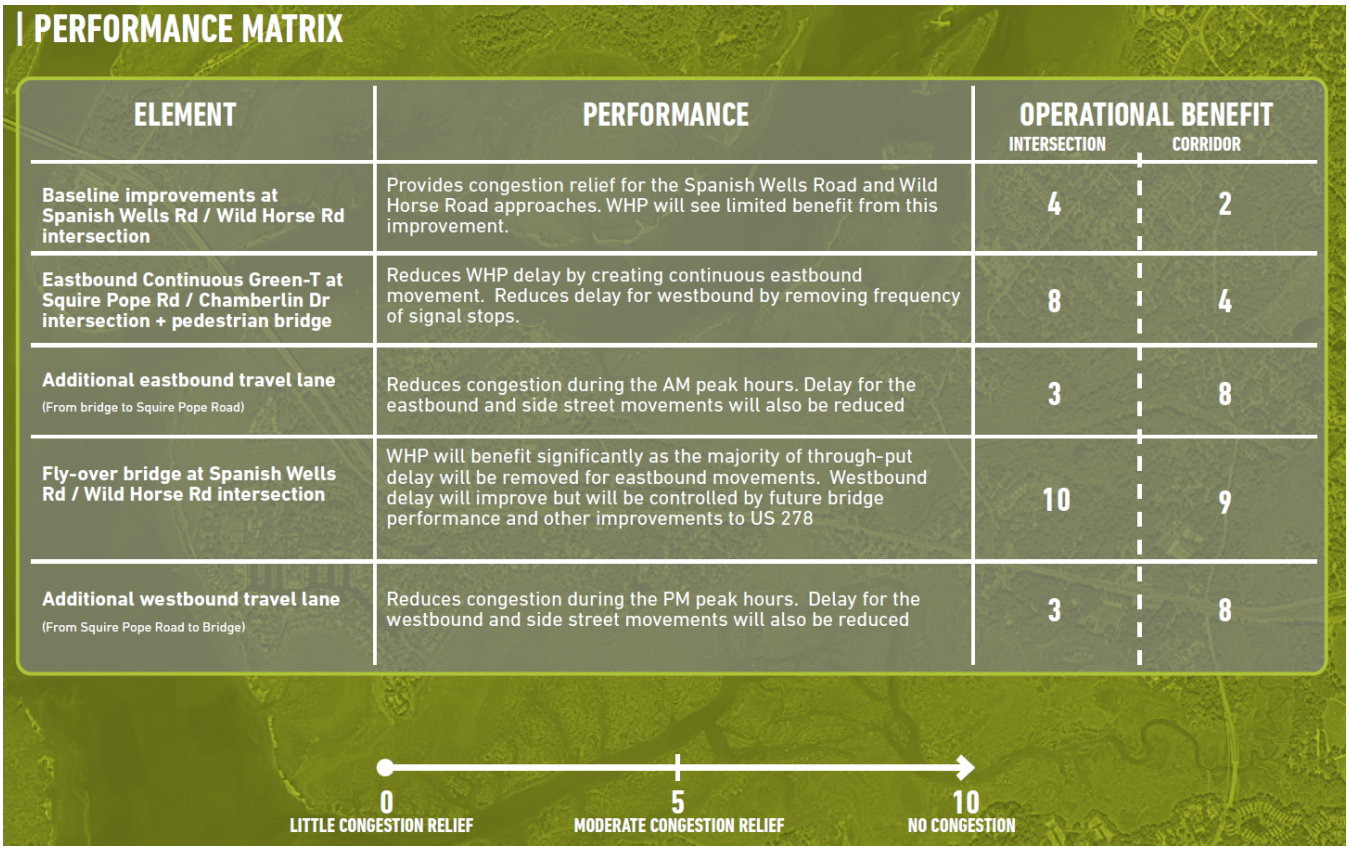
- Improve level of service and vehicular thru-put at problematic intersections with posed speed reduced to 40 mph.
- Enhance pedestrian pathways and create better connectivity in the corridor.
- Provide streetscape improvements (landscape, medians, grading, signage, art).
- Reconfigure Squire Pope Road/Chamberlin Drive intersection to support continuous on-island traffic flow.
- Reconfigure Wild Horse Road/Spanish Wells Road intersection to support continuous on-island traffic flow.
- Establish Gullah Geechee Heritage Park.
- Construct additional eastbound travel lane.

- Construct additional westbound travel lane.

The presentation included proposed roadway improvements to Jenkins Island and Stoney Historic Neighborhood; intersection enhancements to the Squire Pope Road/Chamberlin Drive and the Spanish Wells Road/Wild Horse Road intersections, including intersection enlargements, possible vehicle fly-overs and pedestrian bridges; and design improvements to Old Wild Horse Road.

Mayor Perry raised concerns about how traffic turning onto Jenkins Island might create backups and whether the proposed design adequately addressed this issue. In response, Mr. Kinzelman explained that Jenkins Island access is already included on a broader list of coordination items the Town is actively working on with Beaufort County and SCDOT, noting that conversations and requests regarding access patterns are ongoing. Council also questioned why no Beaufort County representative was present to address matters related to bridge design, traffic operations, and funding responsibilities. Shawn Leininger clarified that Town staff and the consulting team have been consistently engaged in detailed reviews and discussions with both Beaufort County and SCDOT throughout the planning process, even if county representatives were not present during this particular meeting.

Mr. Turner reviewed a Performance Matrix chart showing how corridor congestion is addressed and what the benefits will be as a result of dollars spent:



Council observed that the Performance Matrix was built on extensive data, noting that a full Department of Transportation (DOT) level report would require detailed metrics beyond the summary presented, but also observed that the data in the Performance Matrix shows the operational benefits for improvements at certain intersections, which is key from a summary standpoint. Council also requested clarification that short-term impacts on evacuation routes would be minimal, but that adding a third lane would significantly improve evacuation capacity.

The total cost for corridor improvement projects build-out is estimated at **$125,800,000.00**, as shown in multiple incremental phases in the chart below (further refinement is expected):

PROJECTS OVERVIEW

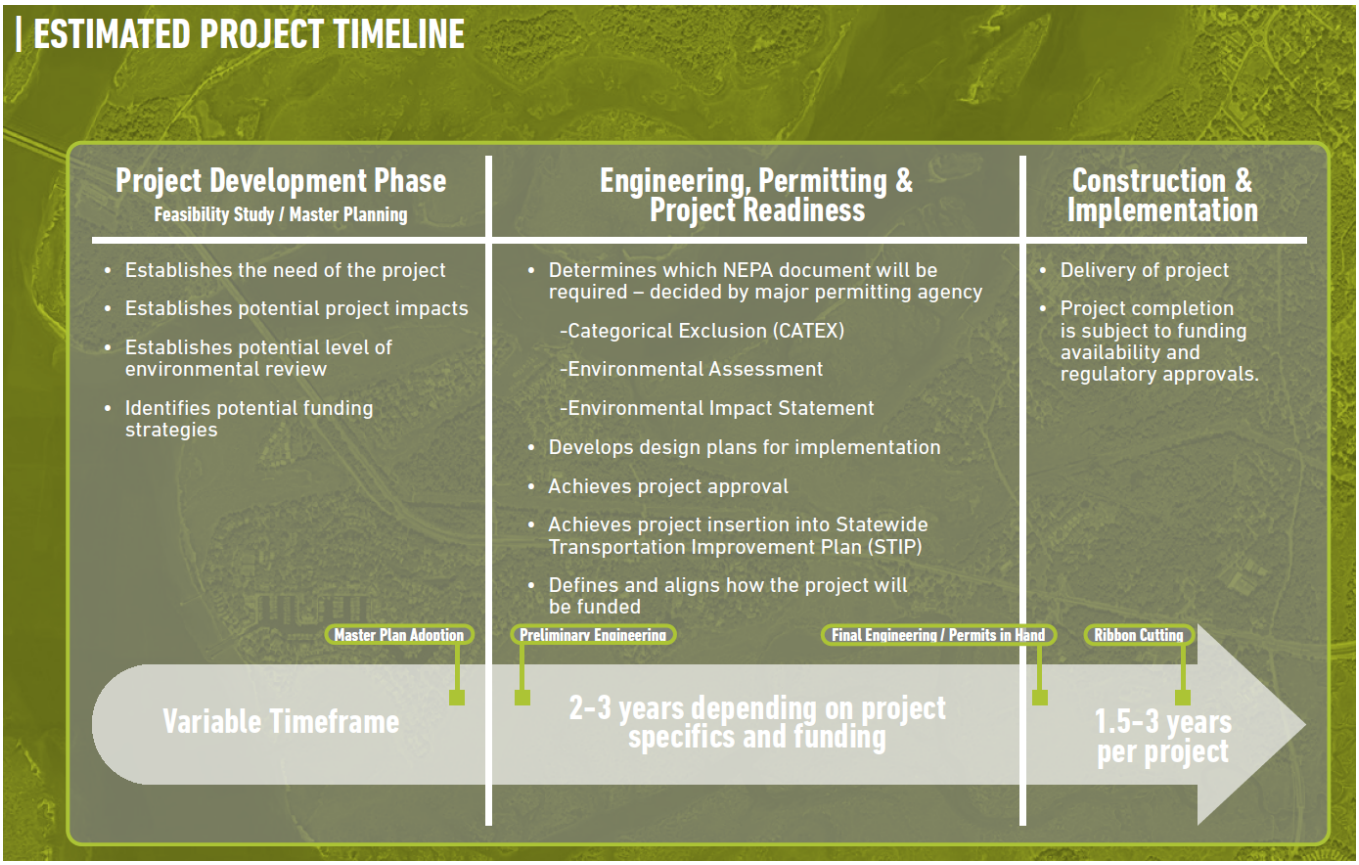
*Estimated costs based on 2025 estimates

PROJECT	DESCRIPTION	ESTIMATED COST *
PROJECT A (INTERSECTION - SHORT TERM IMPROVEMENT)	Implement baseline improvements at Spanish Wells Road and Wild Horse Road intersection	$4,300,000
PROJECT B (INTERSECTION - SHORT TERM IMPROVEMENT)	Implement Eastbound Continuous Green-T at Squire Pope Road / Chamberlin Drive intersection	$900,000
PROJECT C (INTERSECTION + PATHWAY IMPROVEMENTS)	Construct pedestrian bridge west of Squire Pope Road / Chamberlin Drive intersection	$14,100,000
PROJECT D (INTERSECTIONS - LONG TERM IMPROVEMENT)	Construct Fly-over Bridge at Spanish Wells Road / Wild Horse Road intersection including new roundabouts	$36,100,000
PROJECT E (INTERSECTION - SHORT TERM IMPROVEMENT)	Implement intersection improvements at Crosstree Drive / C Heinrichs Circle (Windmill Harbour entrance)	$1,100,000
PROJECT F (ROAD CONNECTION)	Extend Chamberlin Drive to connect with Spanish Wells	$3,600,000
PROJECT G (PARK IMPROVEMENT)	Develop Gullah Geechee Heritage Park	$2,500,000
PROJECT H (STREETSCAPE IMPROVEMENT)	Implement Old Wild Horse Road streetscape enhancements	$4,700,000
PROJECT I (PATHWAY IMPROVEMENTS)	Implement corridor pathway, landscape, wayfinding, placemaking improvements	$16,600,000
PROJECT J (INTERSECTIONS - LONG TERM IMPROVEMENT)	Construct Jenkins Island access road, parking lots, cemetery improvements	$8,100,000
PROJECT K (ROAD EXPANSION)	Construct an additional eastbound travel lane from bridge to Squire Pope Road / Chamberlin Drive intersection	$20,200,000
PROJECT L (ROAD EXPANSION)	Construct additional westbound travel lane from Squire Pope / Chamberlin intersection to bridge	$13,600,000
	SUB TOTAL	**$125,800,000**

Page 67 of 93

Mr. Kinzelman also provided a list of possible funding paths (federal, state and local) and a summary of the procedural steps necessary to meet National Environmental Policy Act requirements in connection with obtaining federal funding, as well an Estimated Project Timeline:





Council observed that perhaps the project scope and cost should be considered when determining at what level funding is sought and secured. Mr. Turner confirmed that project size

and cost should be a determining factor in considering funding mechanisms (local and state vs. federal).

Mr. Kinzelman completed the presentation by providing information for additional corridor project items that need to be addressed by SCDOT and Beaufort County, together with lists of additional transportation system improvement projects for locations around Hilton Head Island.

Mr. Orlando redirected Council in connection with projects that the Town could focus on with respect to making recommendations to SCDOT and Beaufort County. He highlighted that Hilton Head's major traffic issues - capacity, accidents, congestion, and neighborhood impacts - can only be addressed through a small set of feasible solutions while staying within existing right-of-way limits. Key intersections at Spanish Wells Road and Squire Pope Road require either at-grade or elevated improvements. Recommendations to SCDOT include evaluating continuous flow near Windmill Harbor, restriping Cross Island Parkway, and improving signage and lane markings. Mr. Orlando stressed the need for full-corridor upgrades on Gum Tree Road, school-zone safety improvements, speed reductions, and better pedestrian infrastructure; Main Street needs sidewalks, crosswalks, and improved traffic geometry. Additional focus areas such as Palmetto Bay Road, Arrow Road, and Sea Pines Circle require enhanced signal timing and safety work. All these efforts align with the Town's Capital Improvement Program and rely on coordinated action with SCDOT and Beaufort County.

Council members and staff discussed ongoing transportation planning for the US 278 corridor, focusing heavily on whether the current Continuous Green T and grade-separation concepts adequately address long-term traffic flow, safety, and community impacts.

Key points included:
• A request for the County to create a west-end bicycle path connection to the bridge to complement a planned east-end connection.
• Safety concerns were emphasized: eliminating signals could introduce higher-speed rear-end and merge collisions, particularly at Spanish Wells Road and Squire Pope Road.
• A suggestion was made for exploring alternative concepts, including a full frontage road, grade separations, and flyovers, to improve economic development opportunities in the Stoney neighborhood.
• The Town Manager reminded Council that the project does not start from a blank slate, noting prior community commitments, property constraints, and the need for cooperation with the County and State.
• Council discussed whether potential changes should be incorporated into the upcoming Resolution and long-term project list, including adding a future frontage road project for continued exploration.
• Concern was expressed about shifting direction late in the process, emphasizing community trust, particularly from the Stoney neighborhood, which had long been vocal during earlier phases, and clarity is needed to relay that such solutions would require the willingness of all parties involved.
• Council expressed support for moving the current plan forward while ensuring future ideas can still be explored and with an emphasis on maintaining strong cooperation with partner agencies.

Mayor Perry asked if there was public comment.

Richard Bisi addressed Council regarding the cost of the project at $126 million dollars and whether these improvements reduce congestion and travel times for vehicles using the corridor every day and if not, is the cost of the project actually buying improvements and what alternatives might be considered. Mr. Bisi remarked that Senator Davis's expectation was that the Master Plan should be finalized by March 31, 2025, so the Town is behind schedule, the process lacks transparency and the Plan does not demonstrate how it will improve daily traffic. He also expressed concern that the Town does not have the money for the project and that there is a need for enforcement on 278 to reduce speeding.

Skip Hoagland addressed Council suggesting the use of ATAX funds for more police protection and infrastructure that benefits tourists and local residents; that the Destination Marketing Organization is not needed as AI should be used to generate marketing for tourism for free and to run government more efficiently and suggested instituting a tourist impact fee which could offset costs for the corridor project.

Dave Ferguson addressed Council to relay concern that the decision-making process for the 278 corridor is taking too long and why consensus among the Mayor and Council wasn't built sooner and suggested meeting with County and State officials to figure out where those offices stand concerning the project before further voting occurs.

Peter Kristian addressed Council to relay that he manages Hilton Head Plantation and sees that his residents experience difficulty with the traffic conditions to get to and from service providers that are off-Island and that some vendors will no longer provide services for Island residents due to the fact that it is so difficult to get on and off the Island. He also relayed that parents have a safety concern in getting children to school on Main Street, so a safe passageway should be a priority. He also mentioned the possibility of the Town purchasing some properties on the north side of 278 to ensure the creation of a right of way and is also concerned for public safety if it is necessary to evacuate residents.

Christopher Cliffe addressed Council to thank them and the consultants for the presentation and for their willingness to answer questions; he expressed that he doesn't feel that SCDOT and Beaufort County are reliable partners, as they have their own agenda and depending on their cooperation, will result in the Town having to compromise the proposal for improvements and it might be in the Town's best interest if there are some proposals to improve safety and reduce congestion that can be moved forward without the input of the SCDOT and Beaufort County, especially because he feels that SCDOT traffic data is outdated and unreliable.

Council continued discussion on the US 278 Corridor Master Plan, focusing on safety, congestion, community impact, funding, and potential alternatives.
• Members emphasized two core problems driving the need for action: too many collisions and excessive travel time getting on/off Hilton Head Island.
• Council acknowledged long-term negative consequences if improvements are not made, including lost business, frustrated visitors, and ongoing operational challenges for employers.

• Multiple members stressed that the Town must move forward with the plan now, even while exploring frontage roads or other alternatives, because such alternatives require additional property, time, and funding.
• The most pressing immediate needs identified were improvements at Squire Pope Road and Spanish Wells/Wild Horse Road, including the Continuous Green T and short-term traffic fixes. A pedestrian bridge was noted as essential to maintain safety.
• Alternatives such as right-in/right-out configurations and eliminating traffic lights were discussed, with concerns raised about increased vehicle speeds, enforcement challenges, and impacts on the historic Stoney neighborhood.
• Several members reiterated the importance of maintaining community trust, particularly with residents of the Stoney neighborhood, and staying committed to “no right-of-way acquisition” promises that have been part of prior agreements.
• The discussion included financial considerations, including bonding, debt limits, using local sales tax authority (SB 866), TIF, and pursuing CIP funding options to maintain local control.
• Members highlighted the need to prioritize improvements that address safety, traffic movement, and travel time, and requested updated metrics to assess how proposed solutions achieve these goals.
• Several council members expressed support for moving forward with the conceptual Master Plan while continuing to analyze additional or alternative solutions in later phases.

Marc Orlando, Town Manager, thanked the Mayor, staff, consultants, and community members for their long-term input. He clarified that several major projects — Main Street, Squire Pope Road, Spanish Wells Road, Gum Tree Road, Sea Pines Circle, and the William Hilton Parkway Gateway Corridor — are already included in the Town’s Capital Improvement Program and are actively being advanced. He noted delays stem partly from misunderstandings: the Town began corridor work only after Beaufort County redirected $80 million in referendum funds solely to the bridge. Current 2024–2025 traffic data meets DOT standards. Mr. Orlando addressed short-term improvements, including elevating Chamberlin Drive’s priority and exploring Master Plan features that could bring added community benefits. He discussed traffic flow issues around Squire Pope and Gum Tree Roads, potential right in/right out adjustments, and improved westbound access from the Cross Island Parkway with speed enforcement. He reaffirmed his commitment to pursuing funding once Council sets direction, including work already underway on a potential TIF district with Beaufort County and the school district to support Safe Routes to School and key intersections. He outlined the next steps: Council resolution, identifying funding, project planning, ongoing CIP updates, and continued coordination with County and school partners.

Public Comment - Non Agenda Items

Skip Hoagland addressed Council regarding creation of a Master Land Plan, concern for the condition of the bridge onto Hilton Head Island, funding of the Destination Marketing Organization should instead be used for safety and infrastructure improvements, use of Hospitality and ATAX funds; concern that the residents of the Town of Hilton Head Island are paying for the impact of visitors to the Island and suggested supporting tourism by instituting an impact user fee of $5 per person per day to pay for bridges, sewage, waste, drainage, bike paths, safety and other improvements.

Dave Ferguson addressed Council regarding the spending of taxpayer dollars and how decisions are made, including the approval of $250,000 for sponsorship of the Hilton Head Island Jam Songwriter Festival which is a private, for-profit event which sells sponsorships and remarked that there are many local non-profit organizations that must compete through the ATAX process for limited funding and relayed concern as to the Island Jam Festival being held accountable for the spending of the Town-provided funds, what benefit is the event providing for the Town and whether these items factor into the Town's decisions.

Peter Kristian addressed Council to thank the Mayor for attending the Hilton Head Plantation biking event, to thank Council and the Mayor for the Town's participation in the Beaufort County Greenspace Program by putting land aside and lowering density, and to thank Town staff regarding their response to a road collapse on a street being repaved in Hilton Head Plantation.

Savannah White addressed Council as the local field representative for Congressional representative Nancy Mace to let the public know that their office is available to assist residents that may need help in reaching out to or working with federal agencies and federal grant outreach; and to relay that Service Academy applications are open and the Service Academy interview day is December 5, 2026 at the Citadel in Charleston, and there is a Service Academy Day on September 19, 2026, also at the Citadel in Charleston.

Adjournment

The Workshop Meeting was adjourned at 6:29 p.m.

Kimberly Gammon, Town Clerk

Alan R. Perry, Mayor

The full recording and a transcript of this meeting can be found on the Town's website at www.hiltonheadislandsc.gov